

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Show you understood the concern -> Fully -> Before responding or defending

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before addressing a concern, state it back in your own words to show you heard it. Then respond. Not before.

BEST FOR

- Responding to criticism or complaint
- Managing someone who is upset or frustrated
- Negotiation and conflict situations
- Presenting solutions to resistant audiences

PHRASE BANK

Validation Phrases · Showing you understood

- "I understand why that would be a concern."
- "That is a reasonable worry to have."
- "I can see why that would land the way it did."
- "If I were in your position, I would have the same concern."
- "That is a real problem — I am not dismissing it."
- "I hear you — and I want to make sure I have understood it fully before I respond."
- "The concern makes sense given what you know."
- "I would be worried about that too."

Full Understanding · Showing you got the whole concern

- "Just to make sure I have the full picture — is the concern about X, or also about Y?"
- "Tell me more about what is driving that worry."
- "What would make this worse, from your perspective?"
- "What would a good outcome look like for you here?"
- "I want to understand the concern fully before I try to address it."

Stakeholder Validation · Clients, sponsors and senior audiences

- "You are right to press on this — it is the part of the plan with the most risk."
- "That question is exactly the one we asked ourselves. Here is where we landed."
- "If I were funding this, I would want the same reassurance."
- "The concern is legitimate, and it deserves a proper answer rather than a quick one."
- "Let me play the concern back to check I have it: you are worried that X. Is that the core?"

Validation Under Fire · When they are angry, not just worried

- "You are angry, and given what happened, that is fair."
- "I am not going to defend this until I have properly heard it."
- "If that had happened to me, I would be in this office too."
- "Say the whole thing — I am not going anywhere."
- "This clearly is not a small thing to you, so I am not going to treat it like one."

Bridge to Response · Moving from heard to answered

- "Now that I understand it, here is what I can do about it."
- "You have been heard — let me tell you what happens next."
- "That is the concern. Here is my answer to each part of it."

- "I have the full picture now. My response is this."
- "Given everything you have said, here is where I land."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Jumping to defence: 'Well, actually the data shows...'
Better: I understand the concern, but...
Best: That is a real concern — let me make sure I have understood it fully before I respond.
2. Weak: Minimal validation: 'I hear you'
Better: I understand that is frustrating.
Best: State the concern back in your own words, then add 'Is that right?' before responding.
3. Weak: Validation followed immediately by dismissal
Better: That is a valid point, but...
Best: Full validation, full pause, then a genuine response that takes the concern seriously.

DECISION TREE

If Someone raises a concern before you have responded

Validate the concern before answering.

"That concern is valid. Let me make sure I have understood it before I respond."

If You want to immediately defend or correct

Pause. Validate first. The defence will be more effective after.

"I hear that — and I want to address it properly. Let me first make sure I understand it."

If The concern is partly invalid but contains truth

Validate the part that is valid. Do not dismiss the rest.

"The underlying worry about X is real. The specific claim about Y is one I want to address."

If They do not feel heard even after you validated

Go deeper. Ask what you missed.

"I want to make sure I got the full weight of the concern — what did I miss?"

SCENARIOS

Client or stakeholder raises a concern about your work

Understand the concern fully before defending. — "I want to make sure I have the full picture of the concern before I respond to it."

Direct report is frustrated about a decision

Validate the frustration before explaining the rationale. — "I can see why that decision landed badly. I want to hear the full impact before I explain it."

Partner or friend raises a complaint

Show you understood before explaining your intentions. — "I hear that it landed that way. That is not how I meant it — and I also want to hear the full concern."

Presenting a change to a resistant group

Open by naming their likely concern before pitching the solution. — "I know the first concern you will have is X. I want to address that directly."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the concern is unfounded and validating it would reinforce a false belief.
- In situations requiring urgent action where pausing to validate delays a critical response.
- When someone is using the concern manipulatively to avoid accountability.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Pause before defending

In one conversation today, notice the moment you feel the urge to defend before validating. Pause.

Day 2 — State the concern back

In one conversation, state the other person's concern back in your own words before responding.

Day 3 — Full validation

Validate a concern fully — without any 'but' or 'however' until you have completed the validation.

Day 4 — Ask what you missed

After validating, ask: 'Is there more to the concern that I am missing?'

Day 5 — Hard case

Validate a concern you genuinely disagree with or find unfair. Notice the effect.

Day 6 — Pre-emptive validation

Open a presentation or conversation by naming the concern you expect they have, before they raise it.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did validation change the tone of your conversations? Did people feel more heard? Did any feel hollow?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I validate the concern before responding to it?
- Did I state the concern back accurately in my own words?
- Did I validate fully — without a 'but' or dismissal immediately after?
- Did my response actually take the concern seriously, not just acknowledge it?
- Did I ask if I had the full picture?
- Did I avoid validating as a technique to then ignore the concern?
- Did the other person seem to feel genuinely heard?